

Sana M'Heidli, 16-year-old suicide bomber. In her pre-recorded videotape, she said: 'I chose death in order to fulfil my national duty.' What drove her to this desperate act? What were Israeli troops doing in Lebanon anyway?

posts in government would go to the Christian majority. However, by the 1970s, the Muslim population had overtaken the Christians and were demanding more power.

A more significant source of instability was the Palestinians. Many of them had come as refugees in 1948–9 and more of them arrived after the Six-Day War of 1967. However, the most destabilising force of all was the PLO whose armed forces had set up more bases in Lebanon after they were expelled from Jordan in 1970 (see page 81). Soon they came to dominate southern Lebanon (some called it 'Fatahland') and frequently bombed Jewish settlements and villages in the Galilee region of northern Israel (see map on page 25). The Israelis hit back and, when they did so, Lebanese as well as Palestinians were killed.

In 1975 the Lebanese government ordered its army to regain control of the south. The Palestinians resisted and were helped by Lebanese Muslims. Most of the Lebanese army were Christian and soon there was a civil war between Christians and Muslims. Meanwhile, the PLO continued to carry out attacks on Israel from Lebanon. In 1978 a PLO suicide squad went further south and attacked a bus near Tel Aviv, killing 37 passengers.

Three days after the bus bombing, Israeli troops invaded Lebanon. They seized the south of the country but the PLO forces melted away. The Israelis withdrew, under pressure from the USA, and UN troops were sent to keep the peace on the Lebanese–Israeli border. Over the next four years, the Palestinian